JUSTIN DONG: GAME DESIGNER

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Career Profile

I am a mid-level game designer with proven experience across the games and software industries, managing, designing, leading and delivering projects using an agile development methodology, traversing ambiguous problem areas and communicating with business stakeholders.

My expertise includes:

- Adapting and evolving design processes, using rapid prototyping, iteration, testing and analysis to traverse ambiguous problem areas.
- Modelling and documenting level layouts from prototype to release with a range of industry-standard software packages, working with artists and programmers iteratively and quickly to execute ideas to a high standard.
- Experience working on a variety of game types and genres including mobile, VR and PC/Console titles.
- Experience working within a team and establishing design standards and conventions to ensure smooth development and communication.
- Experience scripting events such as cinematics, AI and dialogue to communicate narrative intent.
- Experience working closely with production – maintaining Kanban boards, analysing processes, pipelines and roles to drive delivery and ensure team and stakeholder satisfaction.

Professional Experience

Playside Studios **November 2023 - June 2026**

Playside Studios is a leading Australian AAA studio, known for the *Dumb Ways to Die* series and *Mouse: P.I For Hire*.

Game Designer I

- Game designer in an interdisciplinary, hybrid team, working on a variety of contract and mobile titles across the Work-for-Hire division.
- On Horizon Worlds, released *Survive,* a metaverse action-RPG, *Smash Golf,* a mobile minigolf game, and a R&D tycoon game. All three were demo'ed at *Meta Connect* as an exemplar of the engine's capabilities.
- On mobile, credited on *Dumb Ways to Die*, a minigame collection, *Candy Critters*, an idle merge game, and *Garbage Truck 3D*, a hypercasual game.
- Contributed to and handled technical, progression, systems, economy, retention / monetisation / live-ops design, using data to justify and inform design changes, and ensuring the game vision is maintained.
- Maintained documentation and coordinated feature planning and testing across multiple departments, creating interactable prototypes using Figma, Unity and the proprietary Horizon Worlds engine.

Flow Studio **February 2022 - September 2023**

Flow Studio is an Australian indie game development studio known for Len's Island, a open-world survival crafting game.

Game Designer (Contract)

- Game designer in an interdisciplinary, hybrid team, working on an open-world survival crafting game with dungeon crawling and building elements.
- Released Len's Island: Cursed Underworld, a substantial update that added new environments and play modes significantly overhauling the game's core design.
- Contributed to and handled all aspects of game design.
- Main responsibilities surrounded level design and level art, but also included systems design, prototyping of mechanics and encounter design.
- Analysed and distilled concepts from competitor games to enrich the gameplay dynamics of Len's Island.

- QA analysis and bug-fixing, including handling communication between players and the development team for hotfixes and patches.
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Halfbrick Studios **August 2020 – April 2021**

Halfbrick Studios is an award-winning Australian game developer known for developing games such as *Fruit Ninja* and *Jetpack Joyride*.

Graduate Game Designer

- Generalist designer in a small graduate team building various small arcade mobile prototypes for the casual market in Unity.
- Contributed to and handled core, economy, systems and level design of various prototypes and iterations.
- Analysed market context and designs of reference games in detail to make informed design decisions and drive implementation, planning and other deliverables.
- Managed and drove workflow and process changes in an agile development process as team scrum master.

Australian Taxation Office **June 2019 – August 2020**

The Australian Taxation Office is an Australian government agency responsible for administering the Australian federal taxation system. ATO Online is a free website developed by the ATO, used by millions of Australians to manage their tax and super affairs in one place.

Application Developer

- Designed a large new application as a UX designer, also driving business implementation and development planning.
- Lead and coordinated complex testing strategies and efforts, establishing testing standards and ensuring business coverage, and documenting items such as bugs, new features, and test details.
- Coordinated team meetings and feature discussions with stakeholders, cultivating culture, completing feature and capacity documentation, resolved blockers, bugs, and dependencies while acting as a team scrum master.
- Aided in the development of front-end solutions for existing and new single-page applications.

Education

CG Masters Academy **2022**

- Certificate of Completion: Level Design for Games

The University of Queensland **2017-2019**

- Bachelor of Information Technology (User Experience Design)

Purdue University **2018**

- Exchange student (Fall Semester)

References

Harley Price: Divisional Design Manager at Playside Studios
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